Lesson 21: Enumerative Paragraphs 2: Model Paragraphs, Transitions and Writing

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 2: Sentences and Paragraph Types · American History

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 4 Enumerative Paragraphs, sections VI-VIII (More Enumerative Paragraph Examples; Transitions in Enumerative Paragraphs; Unit Review Practice: Writing Assignments).

In this lesson

In Lesson 20 you learned the topic sentence, supporting ideas and conclusion of an enumerative paragraph; now you will analyze eight more student paragraphs, repair a paragraph with no topic sentence, and learn many kinds of transitions and their punctuation. Then you will plan, write and check your own enumerative paragraph, the book's writing assignment. Varied transitions make academic writing easy to follow.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Identify the parts of model enumerative paragraphs.
- Check a paragraph for a topic sentence and unity, and cross out irrelevant information.
- Use transition words, phrases and full sentences, with correct punctuation.
- Plan an enumerative paragraph with an outline and write it with the writing process.
- Revise and edit your paragraph with a self checklist.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
transition (tran·SI·tion)	a word, phrase or sentence that connects ideas and guides readers	To begin with, … / The second problem is …
unity, unified (U·ni·fied)	every sentence supports the main idea in the topic sentence	Is the paragraph unified?
irrelevant (ir·REL·e·vant)	not connected to the main idea	Cross out the irrelevant information.
cohesive (co·HE·sive)	with ideas that connect smoothly, for example with transitions	a unified, cohesive, and complete paragraph
background information	information before or after the topic sentence that helps readers understand it	It is puzzling to me why Americans wear shoes at home.
writing process	pre-writing (brainstorm, outline), writing (draft), post-writing (revise, edit)	Follow the writing process.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
brainstorm (BRAIN·storm)	write down many ideas quickly, before you plan	Brainstorm for ideas.
hygienic	clean, so that diseases do not spread	Wearing shoes at home is not hygienic.
customary (CUS·tom·ar·y)	usual in a culture	In my country, it is not customary to wear shoes at home.
obstacle (OB·sta·cle)	something that makes it difficult to do something	Travelers have to overcome obstacles.

Rules and explanations

Parts of a paragraph (review of Unit 3)

A paragraph should have: a title; indentation at the beginning; a topic sentence with the topic and controlling idea; background information, if needed, before or after the topic sentence; supporting sentences with specific details; transitions between supporting ideas; a conclusion; and a clear, logical order, so that the paragraph is unified, cohesive and complete (it has all its parts).

Transitions

- Transitions connect ideas and guide readers. The transitions **before the first supporting idea** and **before the conclusion** are often optional.
- "Finally" is for the **last supporting idea** in the body of the paragraph, **not for the conclusion**.
- "First, second, next, in addition, finally" are useful, but not the only transitions. The paragraphs in this unit use these kinds:

Kind	Examples from the unit	Punctuation
a word or phrase at the start	First, / Secondly, / Finally, / First of all, / To begin with, / In addition, / To sum up, / For these reasons,	comma after it
Besides + noun or -ing form	Besides the PE class, / Besides helping me learn English,	comma after the phrase
a sentence that names the point	… is the first problem. / The second problem is … / The part I love the most is that … / The most frequent fight happens when … / The last good memory comes from … / One of the reasons I miss my parents is their food.	no comma: the transition is part of the sentence
a sentence that says "more is coming"	The problems do not end here. / The inconveniences do not end here.	its own sentence
a time clause	Once their visa is ready and they are all excited to leave, they must …	comma after the clause

Writing your paragraph (Section VIII)

- **Pre-writing:** brainstorm, then organize your ideas in an outline. Template #1: topic sentence; question; supporting sentence 1 + details 1; supporting sentence 2 + details 2; supporting sentence 3 + details 3. Template #2 is the "hamburger" picture of the same parts.
- **Writing:** a title, a topic sentence, three supporting ideas with details, a conclusion, and proper transitions.
- **Post-writing:** check your paragraph with the self checklist and improve it until you can check every item.

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Arabic writing often joins many ideas with "and" in one long sentence. In English, start each supporting idea with a new sentence and its own transition.
> - Arabic has no capital letters. Capitalize the important words of your title and the first word of every sentence.

Practice

1. Model paragraphs (Section VI). Read Paragraphs #1 "Shoes or No Shoes", #2 "Unforgettable High School Years" and #7 "To Communicate or Not to Communicate?" in your lesson material. Color code each one (or label it TS, SS, D, TR, C). For each paragraph, write:

- a) the topic sentence (and any background information)
- b) the three supporting sentences and their transitions
- c) the concluding sentence(s) and the type of conclusion (restatement, summary, opinion, prediction, recommendation, question)

2. The transitions table (Section VII). Use the table in your lesson material to answer:

- a) Which two paragraphs have a transition before the conclusion? What are the transitions?
- b) Which two paragraphs have no transition before the first supporting idea?
- c) Find four transitions that are full sentences or parts of a sentence (not single words).

3. Book Exercise 5: "Winter Fun at Home". Read the paragraph in your lesson material.

- a) Is there a topic sentence? If not, add one.
- b) Is the paragraph unified? If not, cross out the irrelevant information.
- c) Add more interesting supporting details.

4. Book Exercise 6: "My Special Place". The transition before each supporting sentence is missing. Add an appropriate transition, combined with the supporting sentence. Write at least two transitions for each blank. Be careful with punctuation.

Example (book): _____ The balcony has a beautiful lake view. → First, the balcony has a beautiful lake view. → The first reason I like the balcony is that it has a lake view.

- a) _____ The balcony is a place where I rest after a day of hard study.

- b) _____ It is a place where I reflect on my life.

Speak with your tutor

- "Give me five supporting sentences without transitions. I will add a different transition to each one. Correct my choice and my punctuation."
- "Ask me the discussion questions from Section VI about 'Homesick for Spain': similar experiences, supporting details, unity, the conclusion. Correct my verb tenses."
- "Here is my outline: [paste]. Ask me a question about my controlling idea and check that my three supporting ideas answer it."
- "Here is my paragraph: [paste]. Check the topic sentence, the supporting ideas and the transitions, then list my grammar errors by type."

Writing task

The book's assignment: write **two** enumerative paragraphs at home, one after the other. Start the second one after the first one is complete.

Topic: choose one. To write about your own topic, discuss it with your tutor first.

1. What is the most significant change you have experienced in your life since you turned sixteen? Explain three reasons why it is so important. (not three changes)
2. What are three advantages (or disadvantages) of Internet dating?
3. What are three advantages (or disadvantages) of social media?
4. What are the three reasons some people hold prejudices against some other people?
5. What are the three difficulties ESL students (or you) have in reading?
6. What are three good qualities of _____ (a leader)? (Name a specific leader.)
7. What are the three words to describe your personality?
8. What is an American custom you like very much? Explain three reasons why you like it. (Just one custom, not three)
9. What is an American custom you do not like? Explain three reasons why you do not like it. (Just one custom, not three)
10. What is one custom that you are the most proud of from your native country? What are the three reasons? (Just one custom, not three)

(Topics 8 and 9 need experience of life in the U.S. If you do not have it, choose another topic, or write about a custom in a country you know well.)

Steps: brainstorm, then make an outline (Template #1 or the hamburger). Write one paragraph of about 150-250 words with a title, a topic sentence, three supporting ideas with details, a conclusion and proper transitions. Type it (double spaced, 12-point font, 1-inch margins, your name and the date at the top right, first line indented) and save it.

Extra (the book's NSNT practice): choose two prompts from Appendix A (Lesson 1), free-write a paragraph on each, then revise and edit them with the checklist below.

Self checklist (from the book's eleven questions):

- Is my paragraph on topic, clear and interesting to read?
- Does my topic sentence have a clear controlling idea?
- Did I include three supporting ideas and connect them with transitions?
- Did I include a concluding sentence?
- Is my paragraph unified and complete?
- Do all my verbs agree with their subjects, and are my verb tenses correct (no tense shift)?
- Are my sentence structure, grammar, spelling, punctuation and capitalization correct?
- Did I follow the paragraph format?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

1. (c: example answers for the conclusion types)

- **#1 "Shoes or No Shoes?"** a) Background: "It is puzzling to me why Americans wear shoes at home." Topic sentence: "There are there reasons why I am having a hard time understanding this custom." ("there" is a typing error for "three".) b) "First, shoes are uncomfortable." / "Secondly, wearing shoes at home is not hygienic." / "Lastly, the culture in which I grew up is very different from the American culture in this area." Transitions: First, / Secondly, / Lastly, c) "Maybe one day in the future, more people in America will follow this habit that brings comfort, cleanness, and respect." (You can also count the sentence before it, "Taking off my shoes at home is a matter of habit for me.") A summary (comfort, cleanness, respect = the three reasons) and a prediction.
- **#2 "Unforgettable High School Years"** a) "Three things from my high school are very memorable even though I was very tired most of the times then." b) "First of all, I loved the physical education class." / "Besides the PE class, I felt relaxed at lunch time." / "The last good memory comes from the change of the hair policy." Transitions: First of all, / Besides the PE class, / The last good memory comes from ... (book) c) "My high school years have long passed, but those three memories still bring smiles to my face and to my heart." A restatement and an opinion (the writer's feeling); no transition before it (book).
- **#7 "To Communicate or Not to Communicate?"** a) "Three subjects often cause disagreement between teenagers and their parents: friends, free time, and school." (predictors: friends, free time, school) b) "To begin with, it is hard for them to discuss friends." / "The second topic the adolescents and their parents often fight about is how to spend free time." / "The most frequent fight happens when they discuss study." Transitions: To begin with, / The second topic ... is ... / The most frequent fight happens when ... (book) c) "To sum up, the fights between the parents and their children often put everyone in a bad mood. Only time, love, and understanding will help restore harmony in the family." A restatement and an opinion (or a recommendation). This is the paragraph from the outline in Lesson 20.

2. (book) a) "To Communicate or Not to Communicate?": To sum up, / "My Favorite Hobby": For these reasons, b) "My Favorite Hobby" and "Homesick for Spain". c) Any four of: "... is the first problem." / "The second problem is ..." / "The problems do not end here." / "The part I love the most is that ..." / "The most frequent fight happens when ..." / "The last good memory comes from ..." / "One of the reasons I miss my parents is their food." / "Once their visa is ready ..., they must ..." / "The inconveniences do not end here." (and others in the table)

3. a) No. "Winters in some areas of America are very cold. Many people have to stay indoors." are background facts with no controlling idea. Add a topic sentence after them, for example: "However, families can still have fun at home in three ways." (example answer) b) Not completely. Cross out "A home theater like this is also fun in other seasons, so they can enjoy it year round." (It is about other seasons, not winter.) Also, "the parents will mow the lawn" does not fit: it is outdoor work that people do not do in a cold, snowy winter. Change it to an indoor chore, for example "the parents will clean the kitchen". c) (example answer) After "Lastly, they can continue with physical activities at home": "For

example, a family can follow a 20-minute dance video together after dinner. The children laugh, the parents move, and everyone sleeps better."

4. (example answers; other correct transitions are possible)

- a) Second, the balcony is a place where I rest after a day of hard study. / In addition, the balcony is a place where I rest after a day of hard study. / Another reason I like the balcony is that it is a place where I rest after a day of hard study.
- b) Finally, it is a place where I reflect on my life. / Most importantly, it is a place where I reflect on my life. / The most important reason I love my balcony is that it is a place where I reflect on my life.

Punctuation: a comma after a transition word (Second, / Finally,); no comma when the transition is part of the sentence ("Another reason I like the balcony is that ...").

My notes